ERA 20

The Movement Begins

1954 – 1963

Brown · Little Rock · Montgomery · nonviolent protest

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did African Americans challenge segregation—and force the nation to confront it?

KEY TERMS

Brown v. Board · Little Rock · the Montgomery Bus Boycott · sit-ins · Birmingham

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 8.6, 8.10 · AMSCO Ch. 8.6, 8.10

CHALLENGING JIM CROW

The Struggle Renewed

Brown v. Board of Education



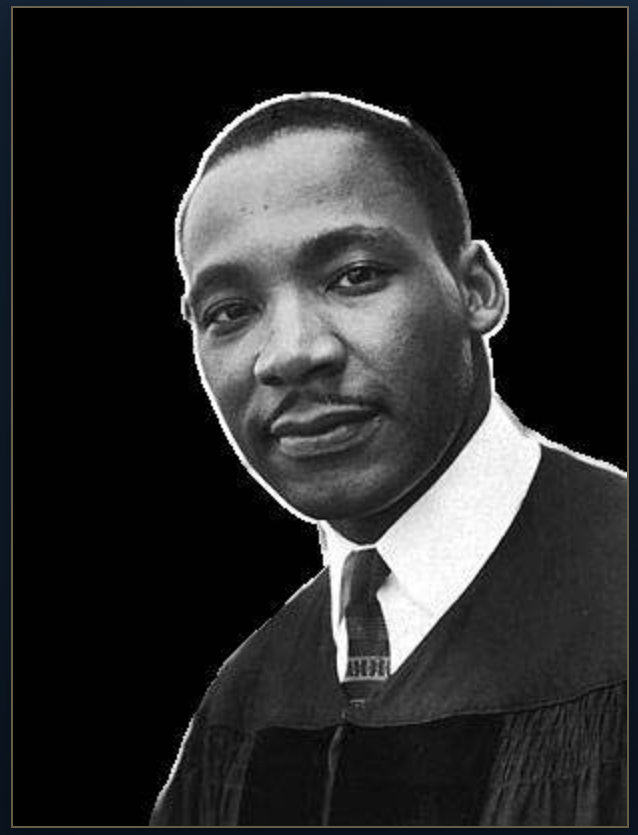
- In 1954, the **Warren Court** unanimously struck down school segregation.
- **Brown v. Board of Education** overturned '**separate but equal**.'
- The ruling declared segregated schools 'inherently unequal.'

Massive Resistance & Little Rock

- The white South met integration with '**massive resistance**.'
- In 1957, a mob and the governor blocked the **Little Rock Nine**.
- President **Eisenhower** sent federal troops to enforce the law.



The Montgomery Bus Boycott



- The 1955 murder of **Emmett Till** had already shocked the nation.
- When **Rosa Parks** was arrested, Montgomery's Black community boycotted the buses for a year.
- It launched **Martin Luther King Jr.** and the philosophy of **nonviolence**.

SECTION

Nonviolent Direct Action

Sit-ins & Freedom Rides



- In 1960, students staged **sit-ins** at segregated lunch counters, beginning in **Greensboro**.
- They formed **SNCC** to coordinate youth activism.
- **Freedom Rides** (1961) challenged segregation on interstate buses—and faced brutal violence.

Birmingham, 1963

- King targeted **Birmingham**—one of the most segregated cities in America.
- Police chief **Bull Connor** unleashed dogs and fire hoses on peaceful marchers—including children.
- Televised images shocked the nation and built support for federal action.



Beyond Black and White

COURT CASE

Mendez v. Westminster (1947)

Federal courts ruled that segregating Mexican American children into separate California schools was unconstitutional. The NAACP filed a supporting brief, and the case helped build toward Brown v. Board.

COURT CASE

Hernandez v. Texas (1954)

The Supreme Court ruled unanimously that Mexican Americans are protected by the 14th Amendment's Equal Protection Clause. It overturned a conviction because Mexican Americans had been kept off juries in that Texas county.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Movement Begins

1. **Brown v. Board** struck down school segregation, and **Little Rock** forced federal enforcement.
2. The **Montgomery Bus Boycott** launched **Dr. King** and the strategy of **nonviolence**.
3. **Sit-ins**, **Freedom Rides**, and **Birmingham** used nonviolent direct action to expose the brutality of Jim Crow.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Movement Begins

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how **Brown v. Board of Education** energized the civil rights movement.

COMPARISON

Compare the strategies of the **courts** and **nonviolent direct action**.

CONTEXTUALIZATION

How did **television** shape the nation's response to events like Birmingham?

Up next — **Lesson 49: The Movement Peaks** (the March on Washington & landmark laws)